IAN SIMONS

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Professional Summary

Network and Security Analyst with hands-on experience Palo Alto Cortex XDR across 875 endpoints, developing SOAR playbooks, investigating security incidents, and improving enterprise security improvements. Holds CySA+, CCNA, and Security+ certifications. Combines expertise in threat detection, incident response, and security operations with a strong foundation in Windows, Active Directory, Linux, Cisco, and Palo Alto technologies.

Skills

- Security Operations - threat hunting, query logic development, incident response
- XDR Administration (Cortex XDR) - IoC management, report creation, custom detection development, incident response playbook development
- Scripting and Automation - Python and PowerShell, log parsing, integration with Cisco IOS and Cortex XDR
- Network Administration - routing, switching VLANs (Cisco IOS), DHCP, firewall administration (Palo Alto)
- Linux Administration - server hardening, system configuration, shell scripting
- Virtualization - virtual machine provisioning, configuration and troubleshooting

Certifications

- CompTIA Cybersecurity Analyst+ (CySA+), October 2026
- Cisco Certified Network Associate (CCNA), June 2026
- CompTIA Security+ (SY0-701), October 2025
- Microsoft Azure Fundamentals (AZ-900), January 2025

Professional Experience

Network Analyst/Security Analyst

Indiana Members Credit Union - Jan 2026-present

- Extended Detection and Response (XDR) Administrator – Primary owner of Palo Alto Cortex XDR across 875 endpoints in a previously minimally monitored environment, establishing alert triage and response workflows
- Alert Triage and Incident Response – Investigate, escalate, and remediate approximately 10-15 alerts per month that are not handled by the Managed Detection and Response (MDR) provider, including anomalous behavior below alert threshold
- Detection and Threat Intelligence – integrated IoCs based on threat intelligence and wrote basic XQL detections
- Security Orchestration and Response (SOAR) Playbook Development – Built 9 incident response playbooks within Cortex XDR to standardize handling of recurring security events and improve response consistency and speed
- Security Posture Improvements – Identify and remediate issues such as poor secrets management practices and MFA fail-open, reducing organizational risk and improving authentication integrity
- Linux Security Hardening - Implemented CIS Level 2 hardening standards on two Linux servers, reducing attack surface and improving alignment with security best practices
- Removable Media Security Program - Developed and implement procedures for evaluating customer-provided USB devices, establishing a standardized process for malware screening and risk assessment
- Reporting and Visibility – Produced daily reports using XDR metrics to provide leadership with visibility into endpoint health, alert trends, and emerging risks
- Firewall and Network Administration – Review and approve/deny web-filtering exceptions, open/close ports, clear port-security violations, and support general network operations on Cisco switches and Palo Alto firewalls

Operations Support Specialist

Indiana Members Credit Union - Jan 2025-Jan 2026

- Help desk Automation Tool – Developed an interactive PowerShell tool for network diagnostics, Active Directory computer management, system information retrieval and endpoint security operations via the Palo Alto Cortex XDR API, reducing manual troubleshooting time by an average of approximately 5 minutes per ticket
- Ticket Throughput – Consistently maintained the highest ticket volume among all technicians (60% above technician average) while meeting or exceeding quality and SLA expectations
- User Training – Trained users across multiple departments, age ranges, and technical skill levels on the proper use of VPN, MFA, and other technologies, improving authentication success rates and reducing repeat support requests
- New-Hire Onboarding – Trained newly hired Operations Support Specialists in core duties, troubleshooting procedures, and help desk workflows to accelerate onboarding and improve team readiness

Additional Experience

- Welder - Arizona Department of Transportation Apr 2023 - Apr 2024
- Welder - Eden Down Home Oct 2022 - Apr 2023

Marine Security Guard

United States Marine Corps - Apr 2014-Oct 2019

- Embassy Security – Provided armed internal security for U.S. diplomatic missions overseas, safeguarding personnel, sensitive areas, and classified materials in accordance with Marine Corps Embassy Security Group and Department of State procedures
- Classified Material Protection – Conducted nightly security rounds to verify proper storage of classified materials, enforcing compliance and initiating corrective procedures when security violations were identified
- Security Training – Led training for Marines in chemical, biological, radiological, and nuclear (CBRN) response, close quarters battle (CQB), proper handling and storage of classified material, and tactical field care
- VIP Support Operations – Supported high-visibility security operations for the President of the United States, maintaining secure perimeters and enabling specialized security teams to focus on direct VIP protection

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Projects

Help desk Automation

https://github.com/ian-m-simons/Computer-Search

A PowerShell-based utility that performs basic network diagnostics, retrieves system information, and queries Active Directory computer objects. Built to simplify routine troubleshooting tasks and provide a consistent way to gather endpoint details.

- Includes modular functions for AD lookups, remote system queries, and network checks
- Used internally to streamline common help desk tasks without replacing existing tooling

Active Directory Attack Path Lab

https://securitywithian.com/posts/active-directory---diy-lab/

Designed and deployed a custom Active Directory lab environment to simulate a real-world domain compromise, progressing from a low-privileged domain user to domain administrator through Kerberoasting, credential theft, and Pass-the-Hash techniques.

- Built and configured a multi-host Active Directory Environment, including domain controllers, member servers, service accounts, SPNs, and intentionally vulnerable privilege assignments to emulate realistic enterprise attack paths.
- Performed Active Directory LDAP enumeration to identify Kerberoastable service accounts, extracted Kerberos service ticket hashes, and recovered credentials through offline password cracking
- Escalated privileges from a compromised service account to domain administrator by obtaining NTLM hashes from memory and executing Pass-the-Hash authentication, demonstrating a complete attack chain and documenting mitigations aligned to MITRE ATT&CK.

Active Directory Hardening Lab

https://securitywithian.com/posts/active-directory-hardening---diy-lab/

Designed and implemented a defense-in-depth hardening strategy for a Windows Active Directory envirnomnent previously compromised through Kerberoasting, credential dumping, and Pass-the-Hash Techniques, validating mitigations against a documented real-world attack path.

- Implemented Active Directory Security Controls including Group Managed Service Accounts (gMSA), Service account logon restrictions, least-privilege administration, and removal of unnecessary local administrator rights to reduce credential exposure and lateral movement opportunities
- Created and deployed multiple Group Policy Objects (GPOs) to enable Credential Guard, LSASS Protected Process Light (PPL), Windows Defender hardening, NTLM restrictions, and additional protections against credential theft and pass-the-hash attacks
- Assessed attack-path mitigations by mapping security controls to each stage of a previous domain compromise, documenting implementation procedures, residual risk, and defense-in-depth strategies aligned to enterprise Active Directory security best practices

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Education

Microsoft Software and Systems Academy

System and Cloud Administration - Sep 2024-Jan 2025

Completed 680 classroom hours of training in enterprise systems and cloud administration. Core competencies include Microsoft Azure, Microsoft 365 administration, Windows Server, Linux systems, virtualization fundamentals, and identity management.